

The consumer goods marketplace is flooded with an array of devices, all capable of networking. This has opened up new vistas, which would have seemed futuristic and far-fetched less than a decade ago. Consumers are spoilt for choice – you can take your pick from among laptops, tablets, smartphones, network-attached storages and consoles. What's more, you can network them in unimaginable ways! You can access your NAS box from your smartphone and use it to play a movie on your home theatre. In this chapter, we'll explore the different available avenues out there, for us to network.

Tablets and smartphones

Tablet computers serve as a great replacement when you want to read a book, watch some videos or just surf the web. However, just like smartphones, much of the use of tablets is dependent on network connectivity. Therefore every tablet manufacturer provides network connectivity in multiple ways such as through Wi-Fi, Bluetooth etc. You'll learn how to take advantage of them in later chapters.

Wi-Fi

The simplest and the most common way to connect to a network is using the Wi-Fi built into the tablet. With Wi-Fi you can not only connect to your local wireless network, you can also access the net if your network is connected to the internet. You can surf the web at any Wi-Fi hotspot which is now common in malls and coffee shops. Most devices are now shipping with 802.11n Wi-Fi which, as we've already seen, is the fastest and most flexible of all the technologies.

2G/3G

If you don't have access to Wi-Fi all the time you should consider a 2G or a 3G internet connection from a mobile network provider. This way you can stay connected anywhere you go. However you will have to pay your service provider too. Most network providers give you the option of choosing between various data plans according to your requirements. There are data plans for 3G as well as 2G but 3G is still pretty expensive in India and 2G is too slow. Although some mobile network operators have started testing 4G networks in India, we still have a long way to go.

Bluetooth

We know that Bluetooth technology is primarily a means of connecting